

CYBER-CRIMINAL ASSOCIATIONS, CYBER-ORGANISED CRIMINALS

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Outline

1. Cyber-criminal associations
2. Cyber-organised crime

Cyber-criminal associations

- Compared to traditional crime, the links between perpetrators of cyber dependent crimes are less likely to result in the exchange of criminal info and in crimes committed in association
- Nevertheless, there are subcultural social ties between hackers (“colleagues”)
- Examples of online criminal subcultures: 1) the modern hacker subculture; 2) the prostitution client subculture; 3) the extremist group subculture
- Cybercriminal associations not very common + arise in 4 ways (the first 2 being predominant): 1) exclusively offline social contacts; 2) 1 + online forum for recruitment; 3) online forums + offline social contacts for recruitments; 4) online forums only

Focusing on the violent extremist subculture

Gaudette T., Scrivens R., Venkatesh V., “The Role of the Internet in Facilitating Violent Extremism: Insights from Former Right-Wing Extremists”, 2022

Research questions:

- 1) What is the link between the Internet and violent extremism?
- 2) What are the interactions between on- and offline worlds of violent extremists?

Focusing on the violent extremist subculture

Methodology:

- 1) interview guide (in consultation with stakeholders)
- 2) recruitment of former right wing extremists to participate in the study

Key results:

- *Exposure:* 1/3 had their first contact with EV as a result of accessing radical right-wing content online; key role of individuals in the offline world; white power music most popular form of online content; wanting to be part of something

Focusing on the violent extremist subculture

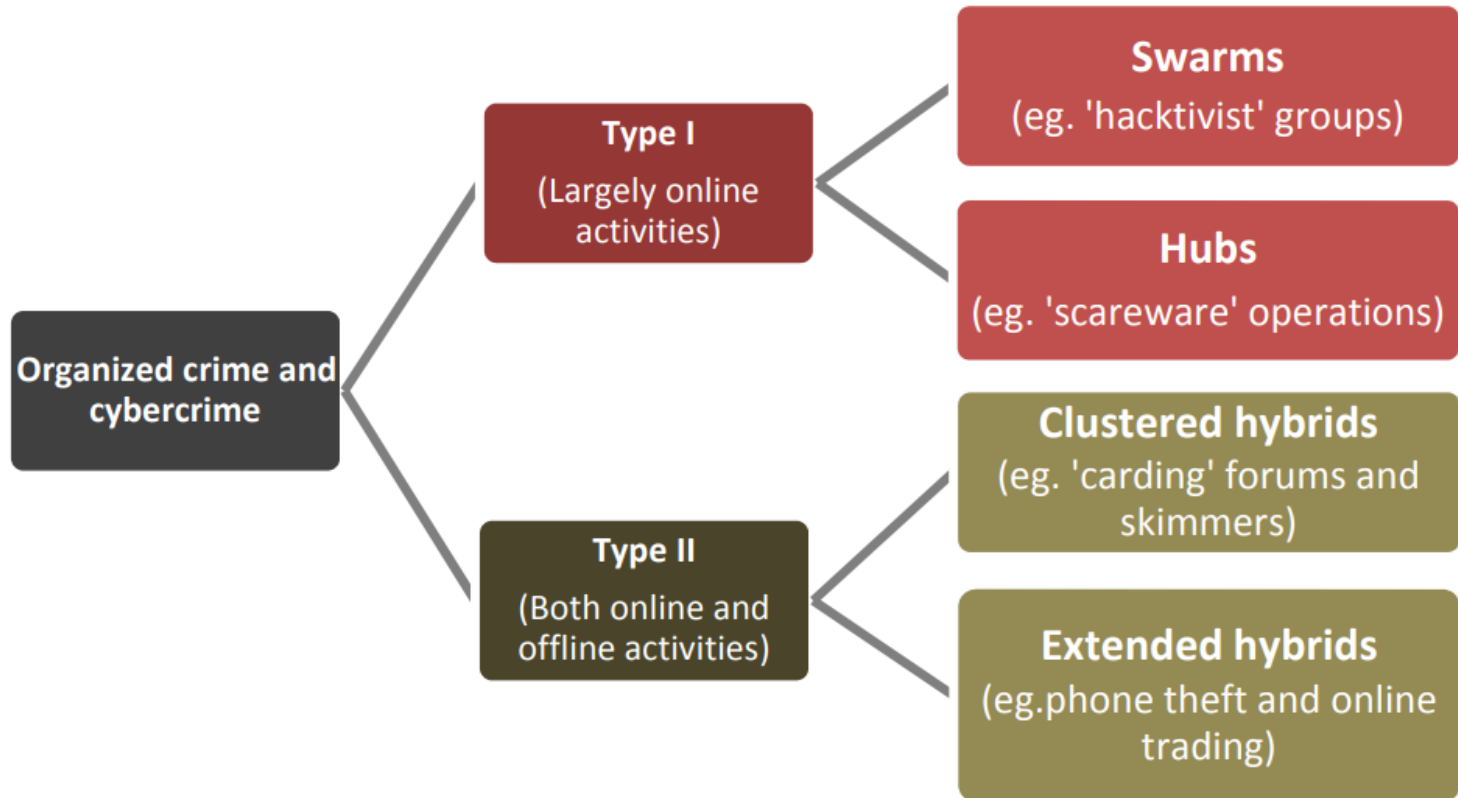
- *Immersion*: **Internet facilitates the process of radicalization**, by immersing participants in extreme right-wing content and a network of like-minded individuals; key role of seasoned members
- *Interactions between the on- and offline worlds of violent extremists* in relation to activities (forums, chatrooms, and social media sites used to advertise events being held in the offline world / digital platforms support recruitment and contacts at the local level), identity, security/surveillance

Is cyber-organised crime a case of moral panic or reality?

- narratives often assume a convergence between OC and cybercrime without strong empirical evidence
- many cybercrime acts require a high degree of organization/specialization, and the level of involvement of oc groups in cybercrime is likely to be high
- McGuire's (2012), based on a large sample of cases, found that up to 80% of cyber crime could be the result of organized activity
- this **does not mean** that these groups resemble traditional, hierarchical oc groups / commit exclusively digital crime
- Wall (2015): “flat” structure, “assembly” rather than organisations, dis-organised model

McGuire's classification

- McGuire's classification of criminal groups that engage in cyber OC



+ **'Type III' group** perpetrating activities that are predominantly offline but increasingly intersect or are mediated through digital environments

Further studies

- How do traditional OC groups run their offline business on the Internet?

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ORGANIZED CRIME IN CYBERSPACE: HOW TRADITIONAL ORGANIZED CRIMINAL GROUPS EXPLOIT THE ONLINE PEER- TO-PEER LENDING MARKET IN CHINA

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